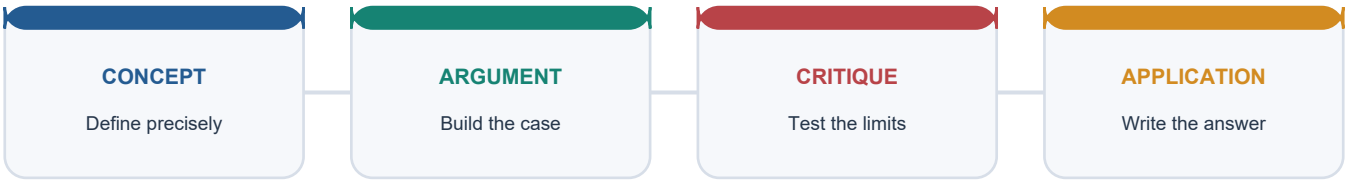
SOLVED PRACTICE WORKBOOK

Crafts, Commerce and Urban Growth (200 BC-AD 250) - Solved Practice Workbook

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing

LEARNING PATH



Deterministic fallback visual: move from precise concepts through argument and critique to exam application.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

CONTENTS / WORKBOOK INDEX

Major learning parts and meaningful subtopics are listed in document order. Page numbers are generated from the final PDF layout; PDF bookmarks mirror the same hierarchy.

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Crafts, Commerce and Urban Growth (200 BC-AD 250) - Solved Practice Workbook

Practice contract: exactly 32 original hard MCQs appear before the PYQ section. Correct options follow A -> B -> C -> D exactly eight times. Every question carries four separately identifiable option explanations, one unique examiner trap and a named remedial target, so remediation is built into the bank instead of being repeated as a cloned block. Four routed Prelims PYQs preserve exact wording and key status. Six original Mains questions (2 x 10, 2 x 15, 2 x 20) are independently isolated. No direct Mains PYQ is routed to this topic and none is invented.

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

32 ORIGINAL HARD MCQS

ORIGINAL MCQ 01

In assessing crafts and commerce between c. 200 BCE and 250 CE, which methodological rule is most defensible?

- A. Convergence of two independent source classes must precede any large economic claim
- B. One large coin hoard is by itself sufficient to establish regional prosperity
- C. Archaeological phase labels may be read directly as proof of dynastic rule
- D. Absence of village craft evidence establishes that village crafts were unimportant

Answer: A.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Correct: settlements, inscriptions, coins and ceramics each answer a different question, so convergence rather than abundance carries an economic argument. [Q01-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: a hoard may record savings, concealment or bullion rather than routine market prosperity. [Q01-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: 'Shunga-Kushana level' is stratigraphic shorthand and is used at sites where that dynasty never ruled. [Q01-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: perishables, informal exchange and women's labour are systematically under-preserved, so silence is not proof. [Q01-D]

Examiner trap 01: A source-rich period still needs triangulation; volume of evidence is not the same as convergence of evidence.

Remedial target: Learners who treat any single spectacular find as an economic verdict.

ORIGINAL MCQ 02

Consider the following statements about second urbanisation and the growth of c. 200 BCE-250 CE:

1. The NBPW phase had already produced towns, punch-marked coins, burnt bricks and ring wells.
2. Deccan and deep-south early historic levels always rest on a prior NBPW urban phase.
3. Some early historic towns have no known prehistoric antecedent.

Which of the statements given above are correct?

- A. 1 and 2 only
- B. 1 and 3 only
- C. 2 and 3 only
- D. 1, 2 and 3

Answer: B.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: it accepts statement 2, which imposes one north Indian sequence on the peninsula. [Q02-A]

- **B:** Correct: the NBPW base is real, and some early historic towns genuinely lack a known earlier phase. [Q02-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: it rejects the well-attested NBPW urban base of statement 1. [Q02-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: statement 2 fails because peninsular levels may instead overlap megalithic horizons. [Q02-D]

> **Examiner trap 02:** 'Second urbanisation' is a north Indian frame; exporting it wholesale to the Deccan and Tamilakam is the standard error.

Remedial target: Learners who assume one urban sequence diffused outward from the Ganga plain.

ORIGINAL MCQ 03

Sanghol's early-centuries-CE plant remains are most safely used to establish:

- A. the crop map of early historic India
- B. that agrarian surplus automatically produced towns
- C. a diversified agrarian base at one excavated site
- D. state control of cropping patterns in the Punjab

Answer: C.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: archaeobotany is site-specific and cannot be generalised into a subcontinental crop map. [Q03-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: storage, transport, security, demand and institutions must convert surplus before towns result. [Q03-B]
- **C:** Correct: cereals, pulses, oilseeds, cotton, spices, fruits and a dye plant together document diversification at Sanghol. [Q03-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: nothing in the plant record identifies who decided what was sown. [Q03-D]

> **Examiner trap 03:** A rich single-site assemblage tempts over-generalisation; state the site, then state its reach.

Remedial target: Learners who convert one excavated assemblage into a regional or national pattern.

ORIGINAL MCQ 04

Which evidence most directly demonstrates specialised textile processing at Uraiyur and Arikamedu?

- A. Mediterranean-linked coins recovered from hoards in the vicinity
- B. Ring wells present within the early historic habitation levels
- C. References to *sataka* cloth in the wider literary tradition
- D. Brick-built dyeing vats of the first to third centuries CE

Answer: D.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: coins attest exchange or deposition, not on-site dyeing. [Q04-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: ring wells are a general urban-infrastructure marker. [Q04-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: *sataka* is associated with Mathura and is a textual product name, not processing evidence at these sites. [Q04-C]
- **D:** Correct: a built vat is a fixed installation that cannot travel and therefore localises the processing stage. [Q04-D]

> **Examiner trap 04:** Distinguish production evidence (installations, debris) from distribution evidence (finished or traded goods).

Remedial target: Learners who accept imported coins or wares as proof of local manufacture.

ORIGINAL MCQ 05

Which find class most securely localises craft production at a site?

- A. Rough-outs, wasters, drills and furnace debris
- B. Finished beads recovered from a burial deposit
- C. Imported glass vessels in a habitation layer
- D. Terracotta figurines from a shrine deposit

Answer: A.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Correct: failed, unfinished and residue material has no trade value and therefore stays where the work was done. [Q05-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: finished beads travel widely and indicate consumption, not manufacture. [Q05-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: imported vessels attest contact and consumption possibility only. [Q05-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: figurines may be locally made or brought in; the deposit alone does not decide. [Q05-D]

> **Examiner trap 05:** The most attractive object is usually the least informative about where it was made.

Remedial target: Learners who argue from display objects instead of workshop debris.

ORIGINAL MCQ 06

The Karimnagar village with separate quarters for carpenters, blacksmiths, goldsmiths and potters most safely proves:

- A. hereditary caste closure among those four trades
- B. a spatial pattern of specialised craft residence
- C. membership of all four trades in a single *shreni*
- D. royal allotment of workshop land to artisans

Answer: B.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: residence says nothing about whether the occupation was hereditarily closed. [Q06-A]
- **B:** Correct: quarters record where artisans lived, which is exactly what settlement layout can show. [Q06-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: corporate membership requires *shreni* or comparable terminology, absent here. [Q06-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: no grant, inscription or administrative record is attached to the layout. [Q06-D]

> **Examiner trap 06:** Occupation, residence, corporate membership and social status are four separate variables and must be evidenced separately.

Remedial target: Learners who slide from clustering to caste or guild in a single step.

ORIGINAL MCQ 07

The Ahichchhatra expression *kumhakara seniya* is used as evidence for:

- A. a royal mint staffed by potters
- B. a caravan toll levied on pottery
- C. a potters' corporate body
- D. a monastic council of lay artisans

Answer: C.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: minting evidence comes from coin moulds and dies, not guild legends. [Q07-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: tolls appear in fiscal and donative records, not in a craft seal legend. [Q07-B]

- **C:** Correct: the first-century-CE seal names the guild of potters and gives corporate identity a documentary footing. [Q07-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: monastic councils are religious institutions, unrelated to this craft legend. [Q07-D]

> **Examiner trap 07:** A named corporate legend proves that *this* trade was organised, not that every trade was.

Remedial target: Learners who cannot cite a specific record when asserting that guilds existed.

ORIGINAL MCQ 08

Second-century-CE Maharashtra deposits with potter, oil-miller and weaver guilds establish all of the following EXCEPT:

- A. custody of a principal sum by a corporate body
- B. recurring provision for monastic necessities
- C. corporate continuity beyond individual members
- D. regulated reserves and uniform rates of interest

Answer: D.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect as the exception: custody of the deposited principal is precisely what the records show. [Q08-A]
- **B:** Incorrect as the exception: the endowments fund robes and other recurring monastic needs. [Q08-B]
- **C:** Incorrect as the exception: attaching the obligation to a body is the point of the arrangement. [Q08-C]
- **D:** Correct: nothing in these records establishes reserves, negotiable deposits, insurance or a uniform interest regime. [Q08-D]

> **Examiner trap 08:** 'Endowment custodian' or 'financial intermediary' is safe; 'bank' imports institutions the evidence does not contain.

Remedial target: Learners who describe *shrenis* as ancient banks.

ORIGINAL MCQ 09

Sangam references to *chattu* caravans carrying paddy, salt and pepper are most significant because they show:

- A. organised inland movement of bulk goods
- B. a documented pan-Indian caravan constitution
- C. that luxury exports dominated internal trade
- D. royal ownership of caravan transport animals

Answer: A.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Correct: paddy and salt are bulk, low-value commodities whose movement implies regular demand and organised transport. [Q09-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: leadership roles are attested, but no standard empire-wide corporate form is documented. [Q09-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: the cargo listed is the opposite of a luxury basket. [Q09-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: ownership of animals is nowhere specified in the reference. [Q09-D]

> **Examiner trap 09:** Overseas luxury lists are more famous; inland bulk movement was larger and is the better opening for an economy answer.

Remedial target: Learners who begin trade answers at the coast.

ORIGINAL MCQ 10

Within Sharma's reconstruction of the northern corridor, Ujjain is best described as:

- A. the western terminus of the *Uttarapatha*
- B. a junction that also received the Kaushambi line
- C. a coastal customs station on the Gulf of Khambhat
- D. a Kushana provincial capital on the Narmada

Answer: B.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: the corridor continues past Ujjain to the port of Bharuch. [Q10-A]
- **B:** Correct: Ujjain receives the Mathura line and the Kaushambi line and forwards traffic westward, which is why its bead industry had several outlets. [Q10-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: Ujjain is an inland Malwa centre, not a coastal station. [Q10-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: no such capital status is claimed for it in this account. [Q10-D]

> **Examiner trap 10:** Junction status, not size alone, explains why a production centre survives the failure of any one market.

Remedial target: Learners who treat every named route city as a terminus.

ORIGINAL MCQ 11

Which statement about Arikamedu is most defensible?

- A. It was a Roman colony administered from Ptolemaic-Roman Egypt
- B. It is one of the ports named in the 2020 Gupta-period question
- C. It was an Indian craft and exchange settlement with imported wares
- D. Its occupation both began and ended with Mediterranean contact

Answer: C.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: imported ceramics prove contact and consumption, never colonial administration. [Q11-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: that question names Ghantasala, Kadura and Chaul. [Q11-B]
- **C:** Correct: the site shows settlement, craft activity including dyeing installations, and Mediterranean-linked imports. [Q11-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: occupation predates and outlasts the peak of that exchange. [Q11-D]

> **Examiner trap 11:** The colony claim is the single most penalised error in this topic; contact is not settlement and not sovereignty.

Remedial target: Learners who convert imported pottery into foreign residence.

ORIGINAL MCQ 12

Pliny's complaint about bullion flowing eastward is best treated as:

- A. an audited statement of the Roman trade balance
- B. proof of permanent Roman settlements in south India
- C. evidence that India imported more than it exported
- D. contemporary Roman elite anxiety about outflow

Answer: D.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: no ancient source compiled anything resembling balance-of-payments data. [Q12-A]

- **B:** Incorrect: a complaint about money says nothing about resident communities. [Q12-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: it suggests the reverse, and in any case is rhetoric rather than accounting. [Q12-C]
- **D:** Correct: it records how a section of Roman opinion viewed expenditure on eastern goods. [Q12-D]

> **Examiner trap 12:** Testimony about a perception is not testimony about a quantity.

Remedial target: Learners who quote the 'drain' as an economic statistic.

ORIGINAL MCQ 13

Which inference drawn from a coin hoard is the least secure?

- A. The region in which it was found enjoyed general prosperity
- B. Coins of that issuer reached the area of the findspot
- C. The metals and denominations represented were in use
- D. The hoard was deposited at some point after the issues were struck

Answer: A.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Correct as the least secure: a hoard may represent savings, concealment in crisis, bullion or ornament rather than general prosperity. [Q13-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: physical presence at the findspot is the one thing a hoard does demonstrate. [Q13-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: metal and denomination are directly observable from the coins. [Q13-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: deposition necessarily postdates the striking of the latest coin present. [Q13-D]

> **Examiner trap 13:** Hoarding often rises in insecurity, so abundance of hoards can indicate the opposite of prosperity.

Remedial target: Learners who equate coin quantity with economic wellbeing.

ORIGINAL MCQ 14

Pali terms such as *kahapana*, *nikkha*, *kamsa* and *kakanika*, corroborated by mostly silver punch-marked coins, are associated with:

- A. the transition to a money economy, but not the growth of urban life
- B. both the emergence of urban life and the transition to a money economy
- C. the emergence of urban life, but not any transition in monetary practice
- D. neither the growth of urban life nor any transition to the use of money

Answer: B.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: it drops the urban dimension that the same evidence supports. [Q14-A]
- **B:** Correct: the textual-archaeological pairing links denominated exchange with the growth of towns, which is the routed 2026 demand. [Q14-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: it drops the monetary dimension indicated by the denominational terms. [Q14-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: the corroboration of text by excavated coin is precisely why both are associated. [Q14-D]

> **Examiner trap 14:** Association is not exclusive causation; punch-marked finds alone still do not reveal every monetary practice.

Remedial target: Learners who answer the 2026-style demand with only one of the two developments.

ORIGINAL MCQ 15

Which combination best justifies describing an early historic settlement as urban?

- A. A fortification wall recorded on its own without other features
- B. NBPW sherds together with a ring well and nothing further
- C. Defences, streets, drains, shops, seals, coins and craft debris together
- D. One imported amphora sherd found beside a stupa enclosure wall

Answer: C.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: fortification occurs at settlements that were not towns. [Q15-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: both markers are widely distributed and insufficient alone. [Q15-B]
- **C:** Correct: each element indexes a different function, and only their co-occurrence indicates differentiated urban life. [Q15-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: an import plus a monument proves contact and patronage, not urban status. [Q15-D]

Examiner trap 15: There is no single diagnostic marker of urbanism; examiners reward the bundle argument.

Remedial target: Learners who define towns by one favourite indicator.

ORIGINAL MCQ 16

Which pairing of site and excavated evidence is correct?

- A. Sirsukh - the orderly street grid of the earliest Taxila city
- B. Hastinapura - a large body of Yaudheya coin moulds
- C. Sirkap - a substantial burnt-brick house with drainage and seals
- D. Sunet - burnt-brick house with drainage, seals and coin moulds

Answer: D.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: Sirsukh is the later Kushana foundation; the orderly layout described belongs to Sirkap. [Q16-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: Hastinapura's early historic phase yields burnt-brick houses, a ring well, tools, beads, terracottas, inscriptions and coins. [Q16-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: this description belongs to Sunet, not to Sirkap. [Q16-C]
- **D:** Correct: Sunet yielded a substantial burnt-brick house with drainage, seals and a large body of Yaudheya coin moulds. [Q16-D]

Examiner trap 16: Taxila is not one city; Sirkap and Sirsukh are successive foundations with different profiles.

Remedial target: Learners who merge all Taxila phases into a single site description.

ORIGINAL MCQ 17

Which statement best captures Mathura's place in c. 200 BCE-250 CE?

- A. A combined route, craft, religious and political centre
- B. Solely a religious centre of Buddhist and Jain patronage
- C. A river port linked directly to Red Sea shipping
- D. A Satavahana administrative capital located in Malwa

Answer: A.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Correct: its inscriptions preserve artisan and endowment evidence alongside route, religious and political roles. [Q17-A]

- **B:** Incorrect: religious prominence is one function among several documented there. [Q17-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: Mathura is an inland Yamuna centre, not a maritime outlet. [Q17-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: it is neither Satavahana nor in Malwa; Ujjain is the Malwa junction. [Q17-D]

> **Examiner trap 17:** Single-label city descriptions lose marks; the examinable point is multifunctionality.

Remedial target: Learners who classify each city under one heading and compare nothing.

ORIGINAL MCQ 18

Pratishthana/Paithan and Tagara/Ter are best described as:

- A. western coastal ports of the Satavahana realm
- B. inland Deccan centres linked with western routes
- C. Buddhist cave complexes on the lower Krishna
- D. Pandya pearl-fishery settlements of the far south

Answer: B.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: they are interior centres, and the western ports are separate nodes. [Q18-A]
- **B:** Correct: both were major inland Deccan production and market centres connected with western route systems. [Q18-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: the lower Krishna religious-urban landscape is represented by Amaravati/Dhanyakataka and Nagarjunakonda. [Q18-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: Korkai, not these, is associated with Pandya and pearl contexts. [Q18-D]

> **Examiner trap 18:** Peninsular commerce must be written as inland node plus corridor plus coastal outlet, never as ports alone.

Remedial target: Learners who reduce Deccan trade to coastal activity.

ORIGINAL MCQ 19

Which formulation of the town-village relationship is most accurate for this period?

- A. Towns extracted from villages with no return flow of goods
- B. Villages and towns formed separate, self-contained economies
- C. A genuine two-way flow combined with asymmetric bargaining power
- D. Villages benefited equally from route and port demand everywhere

Answer: C.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: tools, finished goods, coin and endowment services did move outward from towns. [Q19-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: towns were concentrations of non-food producers and could not be self-contained. [Q19-B]
- **C:** Correct: flows ran both ways while taxation, debt, price-setting and risk fell unequally. [Q19-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: specialised cropping for route demand benefited some zones and bypassed others. [Q19-D]

> **Examiner trap 19:** Reject both the exploitative binary and the romantic harmony reading; the qualified middle is the answer.

Remedial target: Learners who pick one extreme of the town-village debate.

ORIGINAL MCQ 20

Donative inscriptions naming weavers, ivory workers and perfumers are best read as evidence of:

- A. the dissolution of varna hierarchy by commercial wealth
- B. a matriarchal turn indicated by the presence of women donors
- C. universal literacy among urban artisan populations
- D. mobility operating within a persisting social hierarchy

Answer: D.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: a second prestige register was added; varna, kinship and local rank persisted. [Q20-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: women donors show bounded agency inside an unequal order, not matriarchy. [Q20-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: sponsoring a record does not imply that the donor or his trade was literate. [Q20-C]
- **D:** Correct: donation converted craft and commercial surplus into durable public standing without displacing older hierarchy. [Q20-D]

> **Examiner trap 20:** Write 'mobility within hierarchy'; a commercial social revolution is not supported.

Remedial target: Learners who overstate social change from donor lists.

ORIGINAL MCQ 21

The location of Nashik, Junnar and Karle on Deccan corridors most safely indicates:

- A. religious establishments sited within commercial landscapes
- B. monastic control over the movement of caravans and their goods
- C. that Buddhism was exclusively a religion of trading groups
- D. state ownership and management of the excavated cave complexes

Answer: A.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Correct: route-side siting gave these establishments congregations, donors and possibly lodging roles. [Q21-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: proximity is a locational fact and never establishes managerial authority. [Q21-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: doctrinal, political, monastic and popular factors also shaped its spread. [Q21-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: the donative records name merchants, artisans and elites rather than a state owner. [Q21-D]

> **Examiner trap 21:** Mutual embedding runs in both directions; neither monastery nor market controlled the other.

Remedial target: Learners who describe Buddhism simply as a merchant religion.

ORIGINAL MCQ 22

Which statement about political power and commerce is most defensible?

- A. Political unity was a necessary condition for long-distance trade
- B. States altered risk and transaction costs rather than creating trade
- C. Rulers owned the principal craft workshops within their realms
- D. Tolls uniformly suppressed exchange wherever they were levied

Answer: B.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: competing Indo-Greek, Shaka, Kushana and Satavahana polities traded across frontiers. [Q22-A]
- **B:** Correct: security, coinage, weights and works lowered costs while tolls and dues raised or financed them. [Q22-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: the state did not necessarily own production or control merchant bodies. [Q22-C]

- **D:** Incorrect: tolls can finance the very security and infrastructure that circulation requires. [Q22-D]

> **Examiner trap 22:** Political unity is neither necessary nor sufficient for commerce; empires may still contain weak local markets.

Remedial target: Learners who attribute commercial growth to one strong empire.

ORIGINAL MCQ 23

Reduced imported ceramics in a third-century-CE port level most safely indicate:

- A. complete abandonment of the settlement
- B. an imperial Roman prohibition on eastern trade
- C. a change in the form or direction of exchange
- D. the cessation of all craft production at the site

Answer: C.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: abandonment requires stratigraphic evidence at that site, not an import count. [Q23-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: no such prohibition is evidenced, and the causes proposed are multiple. [Q23-B]
- **C:** Correct: fewer imports may reflect redirected circuits, altered demand or different carriers. [Q23-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: craft production is evidenced independently by debris, installations and moulds. [Q23-D]

> **Examiner trap 23:** Decline and transformation are distinct claims; only stratigraphy at a named site supports decline.

Remedial target: Learners who treat every third-century change as collapse.

ORIGINAL MCQ 24

The distinctive contribution of Upinder Singh's treatment, as used in this package, is:

- A. a single-cause materialist theory explaining early historic urban decline
- B. the claim that Indo-Roman exchange formed one bilateral commercial pipeline
- C. the dating of every Deccan cave donation to the second century CE
- D. insistence on mixed evidence, regional profiles and multi-directional trade

Answer: D.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: the single-cause macro-thesis in this topic belongs to the textbook decline argument, not to her source criticism. [Q24-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: she explicitly stresses multi-directional exchange rather than one pipeline. [Q24-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: no such uniform dating is proposed; chronologies remain site-specific. [Q24-C]
- **D:** Correct: her contribution is evidentiary control - mixed sources, regional urban profiles and corporate records. [Q24-D]

> **Examiner trap 24:** Historiography is a disagreement about causation, evidence and scale, not a list of names.

Remedial target: Learners who cite historians without stating what each position rests on.

ORIGINAL MCQ 25

Which term-meaning pair is correctly matched?

- A. *Sarthavaha* - leader of a long-distance caravan
- B. *Nigama* - hereditary occupational group of oil pressers
- C. *Shreni* - itinerant preacher attached to a monastery
- D. *Setthi* - royal officer in charge of granaries

Answer: A.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Correct: the *sarthavaha* organised and led caravan exchange over long distances. [Q25-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: *nigama* denotes a merchant or town corporation, visible on a few coins. [Q25-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: *shreni* is an occupational corporate body of artisans or merchants. [Q25-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: *setthi* denotes a trader or financier of substance, not a state granary officer. [Q25-D]

> **Examiner trap 25:** Terminology questions punish approximate glossing; fix each term to its institutional function.

Remedial target: Learners who use *shreni*, *nigama* and *setthi* interchangeably.

ORIGINAL MCQ 26

Which site-evidence pair is correctly matched?

- A. Ujjain - brick-built dyeing vats of the first to third centuries CE
- B. Ujjain - large-scale agate, jasper and carnelian bead working
- C. Arikamedu - a large body of Yaudheya coin moulds
- D. Sanghol - the *shulaphalayikanam* corporate sealing

Answer: B.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: the dyeing vats belong to Uraiyur/Tiruchirapalli and Arikamedu. [Q26-A]
- **B:** Correct: Ujjain worked agate, jasper and carnelian after c. 200 BCE using Sipra-region raw material. [Q26-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: the Yaudheya coin moulds come from Sunet. [Q26-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: Sanghol is known here for its archaeobotanical record, not for that sealing. [Q26-D]

> **Examiner trap 26:** Site-and-evidence matching is where careless revision is exposed; attach every find to its own site.

Remedial target: Learners who remember the finds but detach them from their sites.

ORIGINAL MCQ 27

Arrange the following in correct chronological sequence:

1. Widespread NBPW towns associated with punch-marked coins
2. Kushana gold and abundant copper issues
3. Contraction of some Deccan and Tamil urban centres alongside changed Mediterranean-linked flows

Select the correct answer:

- A. 2 - 1 - 3
- B. 1 - 3 - 2
- C. 1 - 2 - 3
- D. 3 - 1 - 2

Answer: C.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: it places Kushana coinage before the NBPW urban base. [Q27-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: it places third-century contraction before Kushana coinage. [Q27-B]
- **C:** Correct: the second-urbanisation base precedes post-Mauryan Kushana coinage, which precedes third-century contraction. [Q27-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: it inverts the sequence entirely by beginning with the contraction. [Q27-D]

> **Examiner trap 27:** Sequence items are deliberately written without dates so that the ordering must come from understanding, not recall of years.

Remedial target: Learners who can recite dates but cannot order processes.

ORIGINAL MCQ 28

The irrigation device called *araghatta* is best described as:

- A. a leather bag drawn over a pulley from a masonry well shaft
- B. a masonry reservoir feeding a network of field channels
- C. a hand-pulled bucket used along riverbanks and tank margins
- D. a large wheel with earthen pots tied at the ends of its spokes

Answer: D.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: that describes a simple bag-and-pulley lift, a different mechanism. [Q28-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: *araghatta* is a lifting device, not a storage or canal work. [Q28-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: hand-pulled bucket lifting is not the wheel mechanism named. [Q28-C]
- **D:** Correct: the device is a pot-bearing wheel used for repeated lifting, as the official 2025 Set-A key records. [Q28-D]

> **Examiner trap 28:** Do not substitute an assumed drive mechanism, such as animal power, for the mechanism the key actually describes.

Remedial target: Learners who confuse water-lifting devices with canals, dams or reservoirs.

ORIGINAL MCQ 29

Which statement about the *hundi* is most accurate?

- A. It was a written credit instrument prominent in later sources
- B. It was a silver coin issued by merchant corporations of towns
- C. It was a toll levied on caravans entering fortified market towns
- D. It was a standard weight unit used in the bullion trade

Answer: A.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Correct: it functions as a bill of exchange or promissory undertaking, attested chiefly from the post-Harsha period onward. [Q29-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: it is emphatically not a coin; that confusion is the tested error. [Q29-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: tolls and customs are fiscal levies, not credit instruments. [Q29-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: weights and measures belong to a separate regulatory sphere. [Q29-D]

> **Examiner trap 29:** The *hundi* is chronologically later than this topic's core window and must not be back-projected into it.

Remedial target: Learners who treat the routed 2020 *hundi* question as evidence for 200 BCE-250 CE credit practice.

ORIGINAL MCQ 30

With reference to the Gupta period, Ghantasala, Kadura and Chaul were known as:

- A. capitals of regional dynasties
- B. ports handling foreign trade
- C. centres of monumental stone sculpture
- D. Buddhist pilgrimage destinations

Answer: B.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: none of the three is presented as a dynastic capital. [Q30-A]
- **B:** Correct: they are identified as ports engaged in foreign trade, which tests maritime continuity beyond this topic's window. [Q30-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: sculpture centres are a separate category in Art and Culture. [Q30-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: pilgrimage significance is not what the question tests. [Q30-D]

> **Examiner trap 30:** The question belongs to the Gupta period; it shows relocation and continuity of maritime nodes, not that each port peaked before 250 CE.

Remedial target: Learners who assume every routed PYQ describes the topic's own core window.

ORIGINAL MCQ 31

Which statement about Northern Black Polished Ware is correct?

- A. It is a coarse cooking ware confined to the middle Ganga plain of Bihar
- B. Its presence alone is sufficient to define a settlement as urban
- C. It is a fine deluxe ware whose distribution indicates inter-regional contact
- D. It first appears only after the end of Kushana rule in northern India

Answer: C.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: it is a well-fired deluxe ware, and its distribution is far wider than Bihar. [Q31-A]
- **B:** Incorrect: urban status requires a bundle of indicators, not one ware. [Q31-B]
- **C:** Correct: its fine quality and wide spread make it an indicator of contact within a broader urban material culture. [Q31-C]
- **D:** Incorrect: NBPW belongs to the second-urbanisation phase, well before the Kushanas. [Q31-D]

> **Examiner trap 31:** The word 'Northern' in the ware's name misleads; distribution must be read from finds, not from the label.

Remedial target: Learners who infer geography or chronology from a ware's conventional name.

ORIGINAL MCQ 32

Which verdict on post-Mauryan crafts, commerce and urban growth is best supported by the evidence?

- A. A uniform subcontinental boom driven by Mediterranean demand
- B. A purely political achievement of Kushana and Satavahana states
- C. An essentially agrarian order in which towns played no economic role
- D. A networked, mutually reinforcing but regionally uneven intensification

Answer: D.

Option-wise explanation:

- **A:** Incorrect: overseas demand was selective and cannot explain internal markets or every town. [Q32-A]

- **B:** Incorrect: states shaped risk and costs, but merchants, guilds and producers retained agency. [Q32-B]
- **C:** Incorrect: craft debris, corporate records, coinage and urban morphology show substantive town functions. [Q32-C]
- **D:** Correct: production, institutions, circulation and urban concentration reinforced one another along asynchronous regional paths. [Q32-D]

> **Examiner trap 32:** The verdict must carry both halves - mutual reinforcement and regional unevenness; dropping either is the common failure.

Remedial target: Learners who close synthesis answers with a single-cause verdict.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

Routed PYQ ownership audit

- **FACT:** Four Prelims questions are routed to Topic 19 in the audited local ledgers. Three of them are chronologically or technologically adjacent; only the 2026 money-economy demand sits inside the core window.
- **LIMIT:** No directly owned UPSC Mains PYQ was located for this topic. The absence is stated rather than filled with an invented question, and all six Mains items below are explicitly original.
- **Key-status rule:** only the locally held official 2025 Set-A key is described as official. The 2020 keys are inferred from authoritative subject knowledge because the official papers' keys are not held locally, and the 2026 key is provisional and **not officially verified**.

Solved verified/routed Prelims questions

Solved PYQ 1 - 2020 Prelims GS-I Q25 (adjacent chronological owner)

Which one of the following phrases defines the nature of the 'Hundi' generally referred to in the sources of the post-Harsha period?

- A. An advisory issued by the king to his subordinates
- B. A diary to be maintained for daily accounts
- C. A bill of exchange
- D. An order from the feudal lord to his subordinates

Answer: C. INFERRED FROM AUTHORITATIVE SUBJECT KNOWLEDGE - the official 2020 key is not held locally. A hundi is a credit and remittance instrument that allowed value to move without physical transfer of bullion; it is not a coin, a toll or a weight. Chronology control: the question concerns post-Harsha sources. It is included only because the local routing ledger assigns it here, and it must not be back-projected as a fully developed instrument of c. 200 BCE-250 CE. Confidence: high.

Solved PYQ 2 - 2020 Prelims GS-I Q82 (adjacent Gupta-period owner)

With reference to the period of the Gupta dynasty in ancient India, the towns Ghantasala, Kadura and Chaul were well known as

- A. ports handling foreign trade
- B. capitals of powerful kingdoms
- C. places of exquisite stone art and architecture
- D. important Buddhist pilgrimage centres

Answer: A. INFERRED FROM AUTHORITATIVE SUBJECT KNOWLEDGE - the official 2020 key is not held locally. All three are maritime trading nodes. Chronology control: the question tests continuity and relocation of maritime nodes beyond Topic 19's core window, and is not evidence that each named port peaked before 250 CE. Confidence: high.

Solved PYQ 3 - 2025 Prelims GS-I Q13 (adjacent technology route)

The irrigation device called 'Araghatta' was

- A. a leather bag pulled out of a well with the help of a pulley
- B. a large wheel with earthen pots tied to the outer ends of its spokes
- C. a large earthen pot driven by bullocks
- D. a bucket pulled out of a well by hand

Answer: B (official Set-A key held locally). OFFICIALLY KEYED LOCALLY. In the Set-A paper the pot-bearing wheel option occupies position B, and the araghatta is precisely that wheel-based lifting device. Control: the canonical owner places the term cautiously, notes that its exact earliest attestation is debated, and warns against substituting an assumed drive mechanism for the mechanism described. It is a water-lifting device, never a dam, canal or reservoir, and it is not a core craft-commerce institution of 200 BCE-250 CE.

Solved PYQ 4 - 2026 Prelims GS-I Q6 (direct core-window money-economy demand)

Pali texts contain definite references to coins such as *kahapana*, *nikkha*, *kamsa* and *kakanika*, and archaeological finds of punch-marked coins, mostly silver, corroborate the literary evidence. These statements are associated with which of the following developments?

- A. The emergence of urban life only
- B. The transition to a money economy only
- C. Both the emergence of urban life and the transition to a money economy
- D. Neither of the two developments

Answer: C. PROVISIONAL 2026 KEY - NOT OFFICIALLY VERIFIED. The examinable point is the textual-archaeological pairing: denominational terminology alone would be insufficient, and punch-marked finds alone would not reveal every monetary practice, but together they connect the growth of towns with a transition toward coin-mediated exchange. Control: association is not exclusive causation and does not imply universal coin use.

Mains answer architecture

```
DIRECT THESIS (networked, mutually reinforcing, regionally uneven)
   -> period and source control
   -> agrarian and raw-material base
   -> crafts and corporate institutions
   -> inland corridors, caravans and port-hinterland mechanism
   -> coinage, urban morphology, religion and state
   -> regional comparison and the decline/transformation debate
   -> graded verdict
```

Every body paragraph must be independently useful:

> **Claim -> named site/text/inscription/coin -> what it proves -> what it cannot prove.**

Original Mains practice - 10 marks

Original Mains 1 - 10 marks / 150 words

Question: Explain how agrarian surplus and craft specialisation reinforced early historic urban growth.

Early historic towns were concentrations of non-food-producing groups, so urban growth required a productive countryside and mechanisms for converting surplus into specialised output. First, diversified agriculture supplied food and raw materials. [FACT] Sanghol's early-centuries-CE plant record includes cereals, pulses, oilseeds, cotton, spices and a dye plant; Deccan evidence supports cotton and paddy expansion. This sustained consumers and fed textile and dyeing chains. Second, specialisation multiplied value. [FACT] Ujjain's agate-carnelian working, Arikamedu and Uraiyur dyeing vats and Telangana iron artefacts show regionally distinct production. Third, towns and routes concentrated demand, exchange and skills, while moulds and repeated forms suggest batch production. [LIMIT] Surplus did not automatically create cities: political security, transport, institutions and market demand remained necessary, and site evidence is uneven. Thus agrarian production and craft specialisation formed a reciprocal rather than one-way urban system.

Why this earns marks: a direct causal thesis, four named evidence units, explicit significance and a closing qualification.

How to improve this answer: add one named corporate record - for example the Mathura flour-makers' endowment - to show institutional conversion of surplus, and state what that record cannot prove about wages.

Original Mains 2 - 10 marks / 150 words

Question: Distinguish the evidence for guild corporate identity from claims about modern banking.

Shrenis were occupational corporate bodies, but equating them with modern banks overstates the evidence. [FACT] The Ahichchhatra *kumhakara seniya* seal records a potters' guild; another sealing may refer to arrowhead or spearhead makers. These establish corporate identity. [FACT] Second-century-CE Maharashtra records entrusted money with potter, oil-miller and weaver guilds to provide monastic necessities, while a Mathura flour-makers' deposit funded recurring Brahmana service from monthly income. These show reputation, custody and income-bearing endowment functions. [ANALYSIS] Such arrangements reduced continuity risk by attaching an obligation to a body rather than to an individual. [LIMIT] The records do not establish universal deposits, regulated reserves, negotiable instruments, deposit insurance or uniform interest rates. *Nigama* coins similarly indicate limited merchant authority, not sovereignty. Therefore 'financial intermediary' or 'endowment custodian' is safer than 'bank'.

Why this earns marks: it distinguishes concepts, names three records, explains institutional significance and explicitly controls the analogy.

How to improve this answer: name the regional spread of the records to show why guild powers cannot be standardised across India.

Original Mains practice - 15 marks

Original Mains 3 - 15 marks / 250 words

Question: Examine the relationship between internal trade routes and overseas exchange in c. 200 BCE-250 CE.

Overseas exchange was the seaward extension of inland production and redistribution, not an autonomous 'Roman trade' enclave. [FACT] The Taxila-Mathura-Ujjain-Bharuch corridor linked the north-west and Malwa to a western port; Ujjain also received the Kaushambi route and worked agate-carnelian beads. [FACT] Deccan nodes such as Paithan and Tagara channelled agrarian and craft goods towards western and southern outlets. Sangam *chattu* caravans carried paddy, salt and pepper, showing inland movement behind coastal trade. At ports, [FACT] Bharuch, Muziris, Arikamedu, Puhar and Tamralipti aggregated goods, collected customs, enabled shipping and redistributed imports. Mediterranean-linked exchange moved pepper, textiles, beads, pearls, stones, ivory and iron or steel outward, while coins and bullion, amphorae, ceramics, glass and metals came inward. [ANALYSIS] Ports therefore depended on hinterland routes, while overseas demand could deepen selected craft specialisation and urban consumption. State security under Kushana and Satavahana polities and local toll arrangements affected transaction costs. [LIMIT] Route maps are reconstructions, not fixed highways; imported ceramics do not prove foreign colonies; and luxury trade did not replace internal or subsistence exchange. The relationship was nested: village and craft cluster to market node, route junction, port and multi-nodal Indian Ocean circuit.

Why this earns marks: it answers *relationship* rather than listing routes, uses six named nodes and commodity classes, and qualifies maps, colony claims and trade composition.

How to improve this answer: add one sentence on eastern Bay of Bengal and Southeast Asian links so the nesting is not read as west-facing only.

Original Mains 4 - 15 marks / 250 words

Question: Critically assess coinage as evidence for monetisation and prosperity in this period.

Coinage is indispensable evidence for authority, exchange and connectivity, but it is not a self-sufficient index of prosperity. [FACT] Indo-Greek bilingual and bi-script issues illuminate rulers otherwise poorly known; Kushanas issued gold and abundant copper; Satavahanas used silver, copper, lead and potin; Tamil dynastic issues and Mediterranean-linked coins widened the peninsular record. [FACT] City coins from Ujjayini, Kaushambi, Vidisha, Varanasi and Taxila and a few *negama* issues reveal civic and corporate authority. Coin moulds at sites such as Sunet demonstrate minting activity, while Pali terms such as *kahapana* and *kakanika* are corroborated by punch-marked silver finds. These data show multiple denominations, issuers and transaction spheres. Yet [LIMIT] hoards may represent savings, crisis concealment or bullion rather than routine market use; gold was unsuitable for most small transactions; coin survival is shaped by metal and excavation; and barter, payments in kind and customary obligations continued. Mediterranean coins may have circulated, been valued as bullion, imitated or counter-struck, so their exact use needs context. [ANALYSIS] Prosperity should therefore be tested through coinage plus settlement expansion, craft debris, inscriptions, route evidence and consumption patterns. Coinage demonstrates monetisation's reach and political symbolism, not a universal cash economy.

Why this earns marks: it balances six coin classes against four methodological limits and supplies an explicit corroboration protocol.

How to improve this answer: name one settlement where coin moulds and craft debris occur together, so the protocol is illustrated rather than only stated.

Original Mains practice - 20 marks

Original Mains 5 - 20 marks / 250-300 words

Question: 'Crafts, commerce and urban growth formed a mutually reinforcing system in post-Mauryan India.' Critically discuss.

The proposition is persuasive if treated as a networked, regionally uneven process rooted in an older agrarian-urban base. Production came first but was not isolated. [FACT] Sanghol's diversified crop record and Deccan cotton and paddy evidence supplied food and fibre; Ujjain bead working, Telangana iron, Arikamedu and Uraiyur dyeing vats, ivory, glass, pottery and coin moulds show specialised manufacture. Commerce connected these clusters. [FACT] The Taxila-Mathura-Ujjain-Bharuch and Kaushambi-Ujjain corridors, Paithan-Tagara routes and Sangam caravans linked hinterlands to ports. Institutions reduced continuity and trust problems: [FACT] potter, oil-miller, weaver and flour-maker bodies received deposits for recurring religious provision, and merchant and artisan donors appear at western Deccan caves. Coinage widened transaction options through Kushana gold and copper, Satavahana multi-metal issues, civic coins and Mediterranean-linked bullion. Urban nodes concentrated consumers, workshops, rulers and religious establishments. [FACT] Sirkap's streets, fortifications, courtyard houses and possible shops, and Hastinapura's bricks, ring well, tools, beads and coins illustrate functional concentration. The loop was reinforcing: urban demand deepened crafts, commerce expanded markets, and surplus sustained non-producers. [LIMIT] It was not automatic or uniform. Guild evidence is local, monetisation incomplete, imported ceramics do not prove colonies, and foreign luxury trade cannot explain every town. From the third century some regions contracted while others transformed, reflecting political and route change as well as overseas demand. The system therefore explains a major early-historic florescence, but only through regional comparison and source triangulation.

Why this earns marks: it integrates production, institutions, routes, coins, morphology and decline with more than eight named evidence units and sustained qualification.

How to improve this answer: convert one evidence cluster into an explicit counter-case - a town that grew without significant overseas linkage - to strengthen the critical element.

Original Mains 6 - 20 marks / 250-300 words

Question: Compare the urban-commercial trajectories of north India, the Deccan and the deep south in c. 200 BCE-250 CE.

The three zones participated in interconnected early-historic growth, but their starting points, evidence and political forms differed. North India built on the second-urbanisation legacy of NBPW, punch-marked coins and Ganga towns. [FACT] Taxila's successive cities, Mathura's route-religious-craft role, Ujjain's bead industry and junction position, and burnt-brick and ring-well levels at Hastinapura show established urban continuity intensified under Indo-Greek, Shaka and Kushana contexts. The Deccan combined agrarian expansion with inland-coastal routes and religious patronage. [FACT] Satavahana multi-metal coinage, Paithan and Tagara, western Deccan cave donors, guild deposits in Maharashtra and lower-Krishna centres such as Amaravati reveal a network polity and commercial landscape. The deep south grew from megalithic and chiefly backgrounds into literate port-centred systems. [FACT] Tamil-Brahmi at craft and Red Sea-linked sites, dynastic coins, Sangam caravans, Uraiyur dyeing, Arikamedu craft and import evidence and the Muziris and Puhar traditions show production and maritime integration. [ANALYSIS] North India's route cities were more closely tied to older urban sequences; Deccan growth joined plateau interiors to two coasts; deep-south centres reveal strong port and literary visibility alongside emerging state structures. [LIMIT] These are tendencies, not sealed regions: routes and commodities crossed them, excavation is unequal, Sangam texts were later compiled, the Pattanam-Muziris identification remains debated and dynastic archaeological labels can mislead. Comparison should therefore recognise shared drivers - surplus, crafts, routes, institutions and coinage - while preserving distinct regional chronologies and evidence profiles.

Why this earns marks: it applies one consistent comparative framework, supplies named evidence in all three regions and avoids both uniformity and isolation.

How to improve this answer: add the third-century outcome for each region so the comparison ends with differentiated transformation rather than a static snapshot.